ARTICLE NOTES

Crisis Communication

Youk & Park (2023) · Elgueta-Ruiz et al. (2026)

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ARTICLE NOTES · CRISIS COMMUNICATION · TWO OPEN-ACCESS PAPERS

Crisis communication: one experiment, one field map

Two open-access papers, told so that each can be understood on its own. Paper 1 zooms in: a single experiment showing why adding a scapegoat to an apology backfires. Paper 2 zooms out: a 24-year review of every crisis communication article in the leading journal of the field. This tab shows how they connect. The Paper 1 and Paper 2 tabs walk through each article, opening with the whole story and then the details. Every abbreviation is spelled out the first time it appears in a chapter and listed in the glossary.

CHAPTER 1 · START HERE · MAP OF THE TWO PAPERS

How the two papers connect

PROBLEM
Paper 1 asks whether what you add to "sorry" changes how the apology is judged. Paper 2 asks who studies crisis communication, how, and with which theories.

→

BIG IDEA
Read the two papers as a zoom: one message decision, then the whole research field.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
An online experiment with 392 South Korean adults, and a content analysis of 391 journal articles.

→

RESULT
Paper 1 is a textbook case of several habits Paper 2 describes, and a counterexample to one.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Paper 2 describes the habits of the field, and Paper 1 shows those habits at work. Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) is the theory most articles in the field apply, and Paper 1 builds on it. Experiments are a growing share of quantitative work, and Paper 1 is one. The field calls for new theory, and Paper 1 adds the Theory of Communicative Responsibility (CRT) to SCCT. Only one pattern runs the other way: 71% of the articles come from authors at institutions in the United States, while Paper 1 studies South Korean adults and so answers the non-Western gap.

The order of reading is a free choice. Paper 2 comes first for readers who want the context, because it shows who studies crisis communication, how, and with which theories. Paper 1 comes first for readers who want a concrete example of how SCCT research is done. Each paper has its own tab, which opens with the whole article told as one story. This Overview tab holds what connects them.

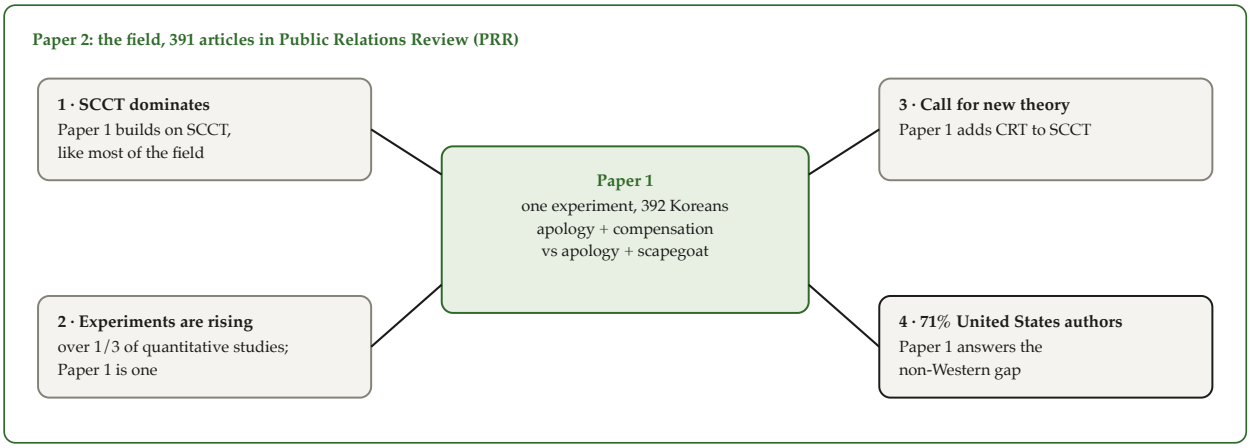


FIGURE 1.1 Paper 1 inside the field Paper 2 describes. The three plain boxes are habits it shares; the marked box is the imbalance it helps to correct.

The two papers at a glance

	PAPER 1 · EXPERIMENT	PAPER 2 · META-RESEARCH
Title	Why scapegoating can ruin an apology	24 years of crisis communication research in *Public Relations Review* (PRR)
Citation	Youk, S., & Park, H. S. (2023). *Frontiers in Psychology, 13*, 1082152.	Elgueta-Ruiz, Á., Sadi, G., Gonçalves, G., & Martínez-Ortiz, J. (2026). *Public Relations Review, 52*, 102685.
Question	Does what you add to "sorry" change how the apology is judged, and does that depend on what the public expects from you?	Who studies crisis communication, how, with which theories, and what has the field concluded?
Data	392 South Korean adults, online vignette experiment	391 crisis articles out of 1,906 published in PRR, 2000–2023
Theories	SCCT + CRT	Maps all of them; SCCT and Image Repair Theory (IRT) dominate
One line	Apology + compensation beats apology + scapegoating; the gap is widest for people who expect the company to explain the crisis.	A booming, United States-centred field that still leans on two theories but is slowly diversifying toward social media and new models.

A finding that links them

Paper 2 even cites a related finding (Zhou et al., 2022): an apology with corrective action works better than an apology alone, and blaming an insider hurts more than blaming an outsider. The scapegoat in Paper 1 was an outside subcontractor, the milder kind, and participants still punished it.

Link to next topic → The next chapter sets the two papers side by side. To study one paper closely, open its tab: Paper 1 or Paper 2.

CHAPTER 2 · SYNTHESIS

Side by side: what the two papers teach together

PROBLEM
The two papers answer different questions, at different zooms.

→

BIG IDEA
Use Paper 1 as evidence on apology design and culture, and Paper 2 for background, theory choice and research gaps.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
A direct comparison, five takeaways and one open question.

→

RESULT
Consistency, two kinds of responsibility, and a practice consensus.

IN PLAIN WORDS

The two papers answer different questions, so they are used for different jobs. Paper 1 provides evidence on apology design and culture. Paper 2 provides background, guidance on theory choice and a list of research gaps. The table sets them side by side, and the takeaways gather the main points of both.

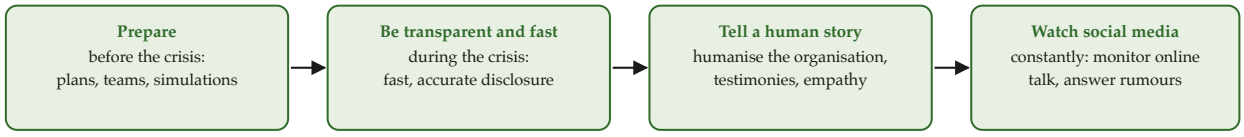


FIGURE 2.1 The practice consensus as the study notes put it: prepare before, be transparent and fast during, tell a human story, and watch social media constantly.

The comparison

	PAPER 1 · YOUK & PARK (2023)	PAPER 2 · ELGUETA-RUIZ ET AL. (2026)
Zoom	One message decision	The whole research field
Type	Between-subjects online experiment	Systematic review / content analysis
Data	392 South Korean adults	391 articles in one journal
Theory role	Tests and extends Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) with the Theory of Communicative Responsibility (CRT)	Counts and classifies theories
Key finding	Scapegoating makes an apology look inappropriate, which drags reputation down; worse for people who expect explanations	SCCT and Image Repair Theory (IRT) still dominate; social media, experiments and new models are rising; research is United States-centred

Main limit	One culture, one fictional crisis	One journal, no reliability check
Use it for	Evidence on apology design and culture	Background, theory choice, research gaps

Five takeaways

1. **Consistency beats a bare "sorry".** A rebuild apology plus a deny move reads as insincere. Pair an apology with action (compensation, correction), not with blame.
2. **Two responsibilities, not one.** Even a company that did not cause the crisis may still be expected to explain it. That expectation decides how harshly its message is judged.
3. **Reputation is won through perception of the message.** In Paper 1, apology type had no significant direct effect on reputation; everything ran through whether the apology seemed appropriate.
4. **SCCT is the default lens**, applied in 92 articles in *Public Relations Review*, but the field explicitly wants extensions (like CRT) and non-Western evidence (like Korea).
5. **The practice consensus**: prepare before, be transparent and fast during, tell a human story, and watch social media constantly.

An open question

Would an Indonesian company's *mohon maaf* (a formal "we apologise") plus blaming a supplier land the same way? This remains open. The mechanism in Paper 1, the norm of collective responsibility and a high expectation that the company explains, may transfer to other collectivist cultures, but the authors tested only Korea and call for cross-cultural replications.

Test yourself

− **Name two weaknesses that limit how far each paper generalises.**

Paper 1: one culture (South Korea) and one fictional crisis. Paper 2: one journal (*Public Relations Review*) and no inter-rater reliability statistics.

APPENDIX · REFERENCE

Glossary of abbreviations and terms

Abbreviations and symbols

SHORT	STANDS FOR / MEANING
AI	Artificial intelligence
APA 7	American Psychological Association style, 7th edition: the format of the references
B	Unstandardised effect size
CC BY	Creative Commons Attribution licence: the open-access licence of both papers
CRT	Theory of Communicative Responsibility. Aune et al. (2005): each side in a conversation judges how much effort it, versus the other, owes to reach mutual understanding
H1–H4	Hypotheses 1 to 4 of Paper 1
IRT	Image Repair (or Image Restoration) Theory. Benoit's typology of image-defence moves: denial, evading responsibility, reducing offensiveness, corrective action, mortification (apology)
M	Mean
NCC	Networked Crisis Communication model: a model of how crisis information and reactions travel through social media
p	Probability of a result this strong if there were no real effect
PRR	*Public Relations Review*: the long-running Elsevier public relations journal and the sole data source of Paper 2
R^2	Share of variance explained
RQ	Research question
SCCT	Situational Crisis Communication Theory. Coombs' theory: match the response strategy (deny, diminish, rebuild) to how much responsibility the public assigns for the crisis
SE	Standard error of an effect size
SMCC	Social-Mediated Crisis Communication model: a model of how crisis information and reactions travel through social media
α	Cronbach's alpha: the internal consistency of a multi-item scale; above .80 is good

Terms

TERM	MEANING

Bloom's taxonomy	Six levels of learning or research goals, from knowledge up to evaluation
Inter-rater reliability	A statistic (for example Cohen's Kappa) showing that independent coders agree; Paper 2 did not report one
Manipulation check	A test that participants actually noticed the difference between conditions
Mediator	The step through which X affects Y
Moderator	A variable that changes how strong the effect of X on Y is
PROCESS Model 8	Hayes' regression template in which a moderator affects both the first link and the direct path of a mediation
Scapegoating	A deny strategy: blaming another party (here, a subcontractor) for the crisis
Vignette experiment	Participants read a short constructed scenario; only the variable being tested differs between groups

APPENDIX · REFERENCE

References

Elgueta-Ruiz, Á., Sadi, G., Gonçalves, G., & Martínez-Ortiz, J. (2026). Meta-research on crisis communication: 24 years of research in Public Relations Review (2000–2023). *Public Relations Review, 52*, 102685. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.pubrev.2026.102685

Youk, S., & Park, H. S. (2023). Why scapegoating can ruin an apology: The mediated-moderation model of appropriate crisis response messages in the context of South Korea. *Frontiers in Psychology, 13*, 1082152. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2022.1082152

Both articles are open access under CC BY 4.0. All charts are redrawn from the tables and text of the articles.

PAPER 1 · EXPERIMENT · *FRONTIERS IN PSYCHOLOGY*

Why scapegoating can ruin an apology

Youk, S., & Park, H. S. (2023). A single experiment on what happens when an apology is followed by compensation, or by blame. The first chapter tells the whole article as one story; the chapters after it follow the argument in order.

CHAPTER 1 · PAPER 1 · THE WHOLE ARTICLE

The article as one story, and how to read its numbers

PROBLEM
Theory-driven recommendations may fall short in practice, because South Korean companies apologise often and pair apologies with other strategies, such as scapegoating.

→

BIG IDEA
What accompanies "sorry" matters: an apology with compensation is more appropriate than one with scapegoating.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
An online vignette experiment with 392 South Koreans, tested with process analysis.

→

RESULT
Perceived symmetry in communicative responsibility moderates appropriateness, and appropriateness fully mediates the link between apology type and reputation.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Picture the situation the participants read. The seat belts in your new car have been malfunctioning, and there has been a crash with casualties. The company says it is sorry. Everything now depends on the next sentence. If it promises to compensate the victims, the apology holds together. If it blames the seat belt subcontractor, the same apology starts to look fake.

That is the whole article. The theory explains why the next sentence should matter, the experiment isolates that sentence, and the statistics show the route the damage takes: the sentence changes how appropriate the apology seems, and that judgement then moves the company's reputation. The damage is also not equal for everyone. It is largest among readers who feel the company owes them an explanation.

The story in five steps

1 The puzzle
South Korean companies apologise whatever the crisis type, and close to half of those apologies were judged insincere.

2 The idea
A company owes two things: responsibility for the crisis, and responsibility for making it understood.

3 The test
392 adults read one crisis and one apology, with one sentence changed.

4 The answer
Scapegoating lowers appropriateness, and through it reputation, most of all for those expecting an explanation.

5 The boundary

This is one culture and one fictional crisis, and it is not a rule to always compensate.

Following the numbers through

Table 2 of the paper reports the effect of apology type at three levels of symmetry. On appropriateness the effect grows as symmetry rises. On reputation the direct effect is not significant at any of the three levels, which is why the authors say appropriateness fully mediates the relationship.

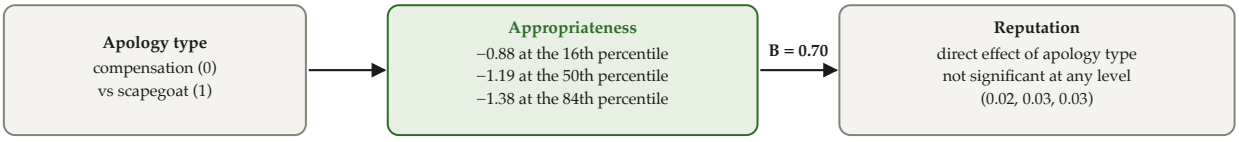


FIGURE 1.1 The figures from Tables 1 and 2 of the paper. The authors conclude that appropriateness fully mediates the relationship between apology type and reputation.

SYMMETRY	APOLOGY TYPE → APPROPRIATENESS (B)	95% BOOTSTRAP CI	APOLOGY TYPE → REPUTATION (B)	95% CI
−1.49 (16th percentile)	−0.88	−1.11 to −0.66	0.02	−0.14 to 0.17
0.17 (50th percentile)	−1.19	−1.34 to −1.05	0.03	−0.09 to 0.14
1.17 (84th percentile)	−1.38	−1.58 to −1.18	0.03	−0.12 to 0.18

What the authors say, and their reasoning

WHAT THEY SAY	WHY THEY SAY IT
The accommodative apology is more appropriate	Apology and compensation are both rebuilding strategies, so using two keeps the message consistent. Compensation also supports the sincerity of the apology, because the company is willing to bear the financial burden.
The deny apology is less appropriate	Saying “sorry” shows or implies that the company knows it is responsible, and scapegoating then discredits that accountability. The authenticity of the apology is easily questioned, and consumers may see the company as deceptive and manipulative.

A more appropriate apology goes with a better reputation	A crisis lowers consumers' evaluation of a company, and that evaluation stays negative unless there is evidence otherwise. A response message is the company's chance to persuade consumers to rethink.
The gap is wider for consumers who put more responsibility on the company	They expect more accurate and proper information from the company, so the deny apology is a greater violation of their expectations.
This is not a rule to always use an accommodative apology	A company must weigh appropriateness against the possible repercussions. An accommodative apology can be used in lawsuits, and in a very severe crisis it may increase the blame on the company.

The same apology, two endings

The ending that held up

"We apologize for the incident regarding the seat belt malfunction." An account of the crash follows, then a promise to compensate the victims. The authors count both as rebuilding strategies, so the message is consistent.

The ending that backfired

The same apology and the same account, but the statement then blames the seat belt subcontractor. The authors explain that the apology implies awareness of responsibility, while scapegoating discredits that accountability.

Link to next topic → The next chapter returns to the start of the argument: the theory the authors began with and the problems they saw in it.

CHAPTER 2 · PAPER 1 · THEORY AND GAPS

The matching rule and its two gaps: from SCCT to CRT

PROBLEM
Theory-driven recommendations may fall short in practice: South Korean companies apologise whatever the crisis type, and SCCT falls short in explaining why a response works from the receiver's perspective.

→

BIG IDEA
A company carries two separate responsibilities in a crisis: one for the crisis and one for informing consumers about it.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) joined with the Theory of Communicative Responsibility (CRT).

→

RESULT
The authors aim to study a non-Western culture, examine variation in apologies, and integrate CRT with SCCT.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) gives a simple instruction: judge how responsible the public thinks you are, then match the response. More responsibility calls for more accommodation. A company that is itself a victim can deny, one caught in an accident can diminish, and one whose crisis was preventable must rebuild through apology and compensation.

The authors saw two problems. The first is that practice does not follow the theory. In South Korea, 78.65% of companies apologise whatever the crisis type, because apologising is a social norm: Koreans rate apologies well and copy each other's. The "sorry" is also often mixed with deny or diminish moves, and close to half of Korean corporate apologies were judged insincere (Kim & Yang, 2012). The second is that SCCT explains which response fits, but not why it works in the mind of the receiver.

To fill the second gap the authors borrow the Theory of Communicative Responsibility (CRT). It separates the question of who caused the crisis from the question of who must make sure the crisis is understood. These are different duties, and a company can owe the second even when it owes little of the first.

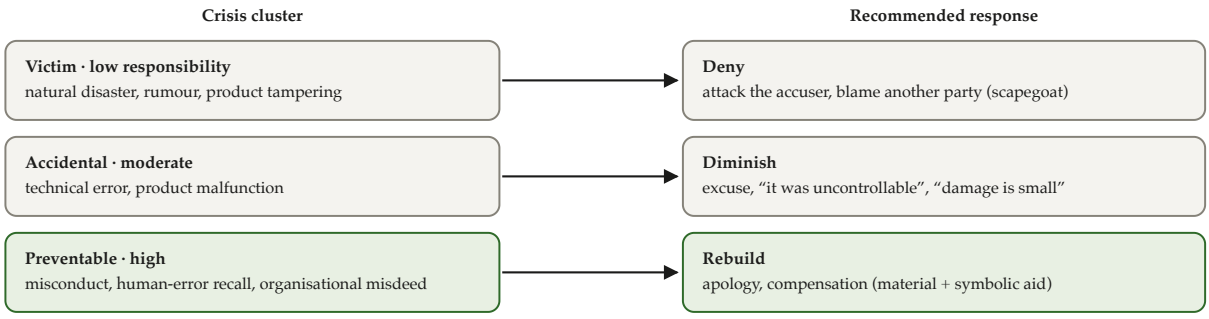


FIGURE 2.1 The matching rule: the more responsibility the public assigns, the more accommodating the response should be.

The matching rule

- **Victim cluster**: low responsibility (natural disaster, rumour, product tampering). Deny strategies: attack the accuser, or blame another party, which is scapegoating.
- **Accidental cluster**: moderate responsibility (technical error, product malfunction). Diminish strategies: excuse, "it was uncontrollable", "damage is small".
- **Preventable cluster**: high responsibility (misconduct, human-error recall, organisational misdeed). Rebuild strategies: apology, compensation (material and symbolic aid).
- **Evidence for the rule**: in a meta-analysis (Ma & Zhan, 2016), reputation falls as responsibility rises ($r = -0.54$) and matched responses work better ($r = 0.23$).

The two gaps

Gap 1: practice differs from theory

In South Korea, 78.65% of companies apologise whatever the crisis type, often mixing the apology with deny or diminish moves. Close to half of Korean corporate apologies were judged insincere.

Gap 2: SCCT ignores the listener

SCCT explains which response fits, not why it works in the mind of the receiver. The authors borrow CRT to explain that step.

Two kinds of responsibility

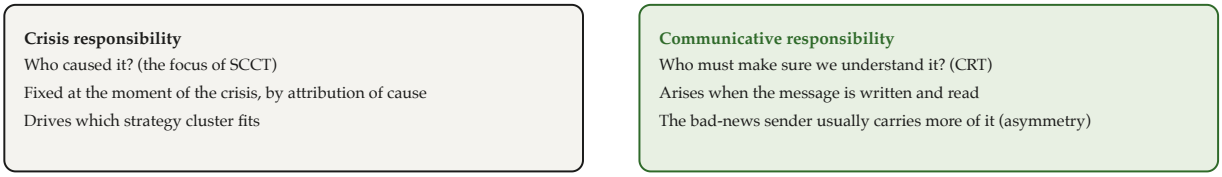


FIGURE 2.2 The same company carries both duties at once. A company can carry high communicative responsibility even when its crisis responsibility is low.

Link to next topic → The next chapter shows how the authors tested these ideas with two versions of a crisis response.

CHAPTER 3 · PAPER 1 · METHOD

The experiment: one sentence changed, 392 readers

PROBLEM
The authors needed to compare two apologies while controlling for participants' existing attitudes and prior experience.

→

BIG IDEA
Use a hypothetical company and random allocation, and change only what accompanies the apology.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
An online vignette experiment with validated materials and 5-point rating scales.

→

RESULT
Two groups read different crisis response messages and rated the same three things.

IN PLAIN WORDS

A vignette experiment asks participants to read a short constructed scenario in which only the variable being tested differs between groups. Here, 392 South Korean adults from a national online panel imagined that the seat belts in their new car had been malfunctioning, then read news of a crash with casualties. They were split at random into two groups, and each read a version of the company's response.

Both versions apologised in the same words and gave the same account of the crash. They differed in one sentence. The accommodative apology added a promise to compensate the victims. The deny apology blamed the seat belt subcontractor. Everyone then rated the same three things, which means a difference between groups points back to that one sentence.

The company was fictional, so prior attitudes toward a real brand could not leak in. The seat-belt scenario was chosen because Korean auto crises are often safety defects, and the materials had been validated in an earlier study (Im et al., 2021).

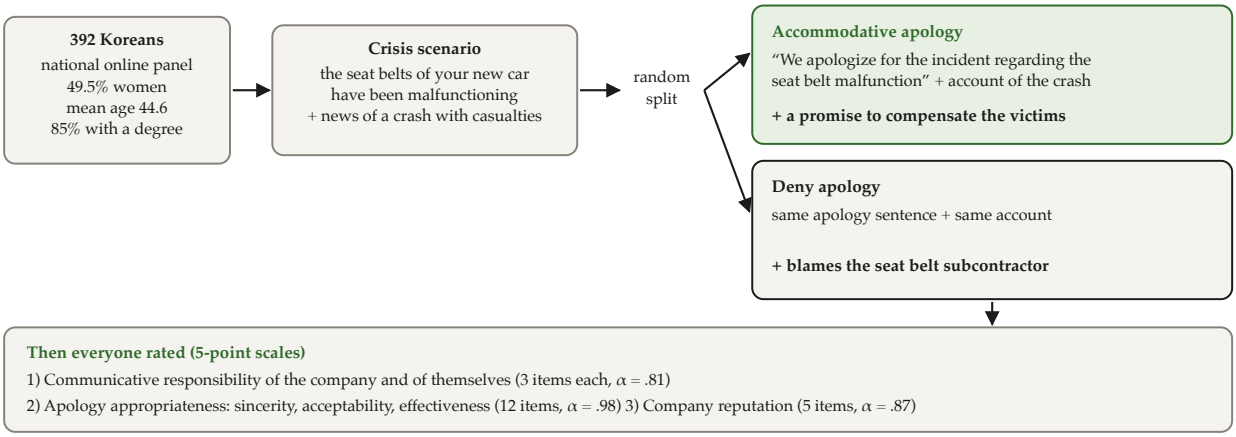


FIGURE 3.1 Only one sentence differs between the two versions. Everyone reads the same crisis and the same apology sentence, then the same three rating scales follow.

The sample

- **Size and source**: 392 South Koreans from a national online panel.
- **Profile**: 49.5% women, mean age 44.6, 85% with a degree.

The measures

All three measures used 5-point scales, and all were reliable. Cronbach's α measures the internal consistency of a multi-item scale, and a value above .80 is good.

MEASURE	ITEMS	A
Communicative responsibility of the company, and of the participant	3 each	.81
Apology appropriateness: sincerity, acceptability, effectiveness	12	.98
Company reputation	5	.87

How "symmetry" was scored

The symmetry score is the company's communicative responsibility minus the participant's own.

```
Symmetry = company's responsibility − participant's own
Above 0: the company should do more of the explaining than me
Exactly 0: the duty is shared equally
Below 0: it is on me to understand
```

Link to next topic → With the data collected, the authors tested a model that places appropriateness between the apology and the reputation.

CHAPTER 4 · PAPER 1 · MODEL

The model they tested: mediated moderation

PROBLEM
The authors hypothesised that appropriateness links apology type to reputation, and that this varies with what consumers expect from the company.

→

BIG IDEA
Apology type works through appropriateness, and symmetry changes the strength of the first step.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
A mediated moderation analysis using PROCESS Model 8.

→

RESULT
Scapegoating cuts appropriateness by 1.16 points, and reputation moves only through appropriateness.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Two terms carry this chapter. A mediator is the step through which one variable affects another. A moderator is a variable that changes how strong that effect is. The model combines them: apology type affects reputation through appropriateness, and the first link is stronger or weaker depending on a person's symmetry score.

The coefficients tell the story in order. Moving from compensation to scapegoating cuts perceived appropriateness by 1.16 points on a 5-point scale. Each point of appropriateness then lifts reputation by 0.70. The direct path from apology type to reputation has a coefficient of just 0.03, which is not significant, so the whole effect travels through the judgement of the apology.

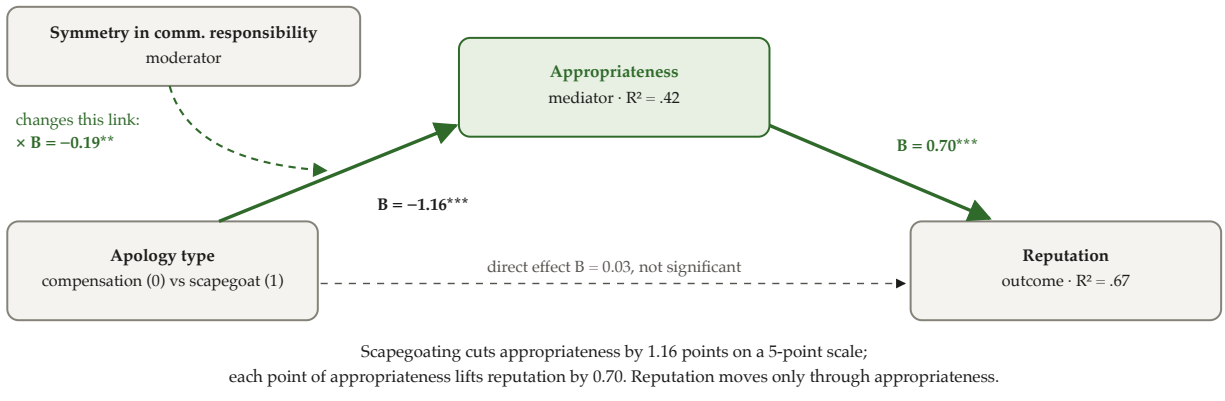


FIGURE 4.1 *** p < .001, ** p < .01. Coefficients are unstandardised (B), from Table 1 of the paper.

The coefficients to remember

PATH	B	MEANING
Apology type → appropriateness	−1.16***	The scapegoat version is rated less appropriate

Apology type × symmetry → appropriateness	−0.19**	The drop is larger for people with higher symmetry scores
Appropriateness → reputation	0.70***	A more appropriate apology goes with a better reputation
Apology type → reputation (direct)	0.03	Not significant

Variance explained

- **Appropriateness**: $R^2 = .42$.
- **Reputation**: $R^2 = .67$.

Reading the statistics

- **B**: an unstandardised effect size.
- **R^2**: the share of variance explained.
- **p**: the probability of a result this strong if there were no real effect.
- **PROCESS Model 8**: Hayes' regression template in which a moderator affects both the first link and the direct path of a mediation.

Link to next topic → The next chapter sets each prediction against its evidence and shows the interaction as a picture.

CHAPTER 5 · PAPER 1 · RESULTS

What they found: every prediction supported

PROBLEM
Four hypotheses and one research question needed testing against the data.

→

BIG IDEA
Everyone rates the compensation apology about the same; the scapegoat apology splits people.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
A manipulation check, regression paths and simple slopes at three levels of symmetry.

→

RESULT
All four hypotheses are supported, and the direct effect on reputation is absent.

IN PLAIN WORDS

A manipulation check tests whether participants actually noticed the difference between conditions. They did: the compensation version read as accepting far more blame (mean 3.87 against 2.22). With that settled, each hypothesis held. Compensation made the apology more appropriate, appropriateness improved reputation, people expected the company to do more of the explaining, and that expectation widened the gap between the two apologies.

The key picture is the slope chart. Starting from the compensation apology, all three lines begin at about the same height. Moving to the scapegoat apology, all three fall, but the line for people who most expect the company to explain falls furthest. Scapegoating hurts everyone's judgement of the apology, and it hurts most among those who feel owed an explanation.

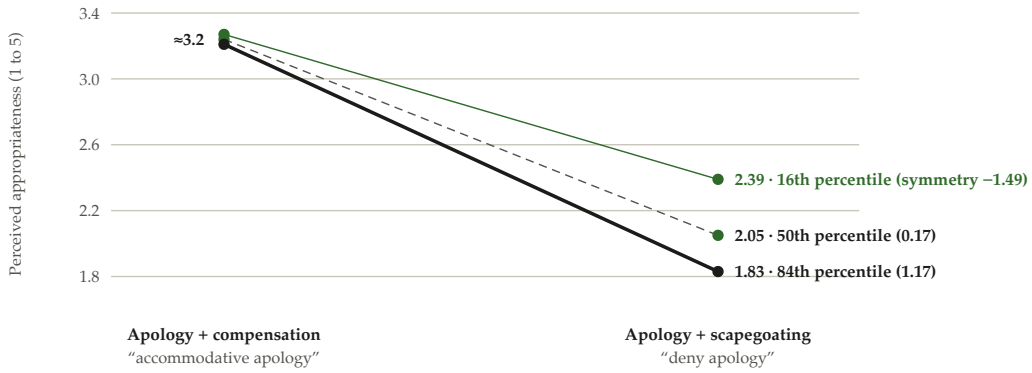


FIGURE 5.1 The key picture, redrawn from Fig. 2 of the paper. Everyone rates the compensation apology about the same. The scapegoat apology drops for everyone, but drops hardest for people who most expect the company to explain the crisis: −0.88 against −1.38 points.

Prediction by prediction

#	PREDICTION	EVIDENCE	VERDICT

Check	The compensation version reads as accepting more blame	Accepted responsibility M = 3.87 vs 2.22, t(390) = 19.62	Worked
H1	Apology + compensation is more appropriate	B = −1.16 for the scapegoat version	Supported
H2	A more appropriate apology goes with a better reputation	B = 0.70	Supported
H3	People expect the company to do more of the explaining	Mean symmetry 1.49 > 0, t(391) = 25.13	Supported
H4	That expectation widens the gap between the two apologies	Interaction B = −0.19	Supported
RQ1	Does apology type hit reputation directly?	Direct effect not significant at any level	No: fully mediated

Who holds the duty to explain

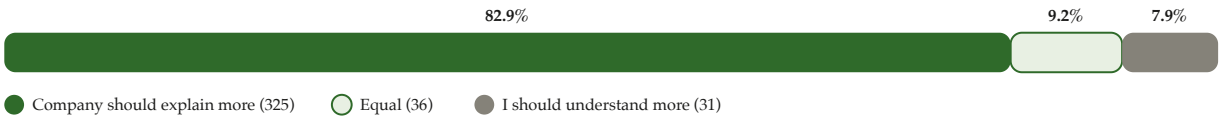


FIGURE 5.2 H3 in one bar: 83% put the explaining burden on the company. The 8% who did not are part of why the moderator varies.

Reading the slope chart: the paper states that the moderator was mean-centered, so the symmetry values on the lines (−1.49, 0.17, 1.17) are measured from the mean. They are not raw scores, and the raw mean is 1.49. The authors describe the 84th percentile as people who see the company as having relatively high communicative responsibility, and the lower percentile as those who put less of the burden on the company.

Link to next topic → The last chapter on Paper 1 explains why the scapegoat fails and how far the result can be carried.

CHAPTER 6 · PAPER 1 · ANALYSIS

Why scapegoating backfires, and how far the result travels

PROBLEM
The authors warn that the results should not be read as "always use an accommodative apology".

→

BIG IDEA
"Sorry" implies fault, so what follows must agree with it.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
The authors' discussion and limitations, together with the reading in the study notes.

→

RESULT
Evidence from one culture and one crisis, with the authors calling for cross-cultural studies.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Saying "sorry" implies "it is our fault". Compensation confirms that message: two rebuild strategies, one consistent meaning. Scapegoating contradicts it: a rebuild move glued to a deny move, so the "sorry" looks fake. People who feel the company owes them a clear explanation read the contradiction as a broken expectation, and punish it more. In collectivist Korea, pushing blame onto one part of the chain, such as a subcontractor, may also clash with the norm of collective responsibility.

The authors warn that this is not a rule to always compensate. A deny apology may be relatively fine when the crisis is simple to understand, when the culture tolerates uncertainty, or when the company is clearly a victim too. Compensation also carries costs: legal liability, and a harsh crisis can make an admission of fault fuel more blame.

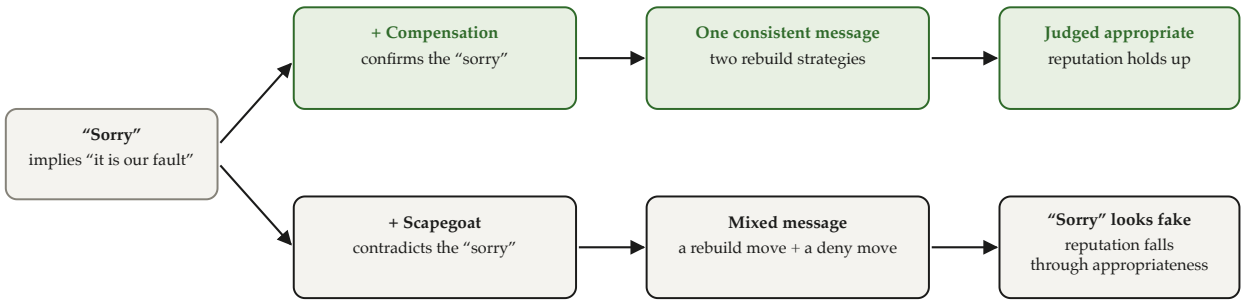


FIGURE 6.1 Why the same "sorry" lands differently. The upper route stays consistent from start to finish, and the lower route breaks at the second step.

Strengths and limits

Strengths, as read in the study notes

- Tests the **mechanism** (why), not just the outcome, as Coombs & Holladay (2002) asked for.
- Clean manipulation: only one sentence differs between conditions.
- Very reliable scales (α .81 to .98), a national panel, and income that matches the national median.
- Brings a non-Western culture into Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) and connects SCCT to linguistics (Grice, and the Theory of Communicative Responsibility).

Limits

- Stated by the authors: one culture and one crisis (a product malfunction), which could be read as accidental or preventable.
- Stated by the authors: a hypothetical company leaves out crisis history, which future research could examine using an existing organisation.
- From the study notes: vignettes measure reactions on paper, not real behaviour such as buying or boycotting.
- From the study notes: with no "apology only" control, it cannot show how much compensation adds and how much scapegoating subtracts.

> **Do not over-read it:** the finding is that apology plus compensation beat apology plus scapegoating, for one crisis, in one culture. It is not evidence that compensation is always the right response.

Test yourself

− In Paper 1, what is the difference between crisis responsibility and communicative responsibility?

Crisis responsibility is about who *caused* the crisis (the attribution in SCCT). Communicative responsibility is about who must make sure the crisis is *understood* (CRT). A company can carry high communicative responsibility even when crisis responsibility is low.

− Why is the result called a “mediated moderation”?

Mediated: apology type affects reputation only through appropriateness (direct effect not significant). Moderated: the link from apology to appropriateness is stronger for people with high symmetry scores (interaction B = −0.19).

Link to next topic → Paper 2 steps back from this one experiment to the 391 articles around it.

PAPER 2 · META-RESEARCH · *PUBLIC RELATIONS REVIEW*

24 years of crisis communication research

Elgueta-Ruiz, Á., Sadi, G., Gonçalves, G., & Martínez-Ortiz, J. (2026). A review of every crisis communication article in one journal from 2000 to 2023. The first chapter tells the whole article as one story; the chapters after it go through the map section by section.

CHAPTER 1 · PAPER 2 · THE WHOLE ARTICLE

The article as one story, and how to read its counts

PROBLEM
Despite the growing literature, a systematic approach to crisis communication research is still limited.

→

BIG IDEA
Analyse all articles on the topic in the leading journal of the field.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
A qualitative and quantitative content analysis of 391 of the 1,906 articles published from 2000 to 2023.

→

RESULT
Authors, universities, networks, objectives, methods, theories, results and conclusions, with their theoretical and practical implications.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Paper 2 is research about research. Instead of testing a message on people, the authors read every crisis communication article published in one journal over 24 years and recorded what each one did: who wrote it, how it was done, which theory it used and what it concluded. The result is a map of a field's habits.

The map tells a simple story. Crisis communication has grown into the most frequent topic in the journal. The work is centred on the United States, leans on two theories and is slowly widening toward social media and new models. Read across all these articles, the conclusions come down to four pillars. The authors themselves note that the focus on one journal restricts how far the results generalise to the broader field.

The story in five steps

1 The question
Who studies crisis communication, how, with which theories, and what has the field concluded?

2 The corpus
391 crisis articles out of 1,906 in *Public Relations Review* (PRR), 2000–2023, each coded by hand.

3 The profile
A booming, United States-centred field, with quantitative work in the lead and experiments rising.

4 The theories
Situational Crisis Communication Theory and Image Repair Theory dominate, while alternatives gain ground.

5 The advice
Preparedness, transparency, narrative and digital agility.

How the counts nest

Each count in the article sits inside a larger one. The paper reports the 66 experiments in two ways: as 16.87% of all articles, and as more than one-third of all quantitative studies.

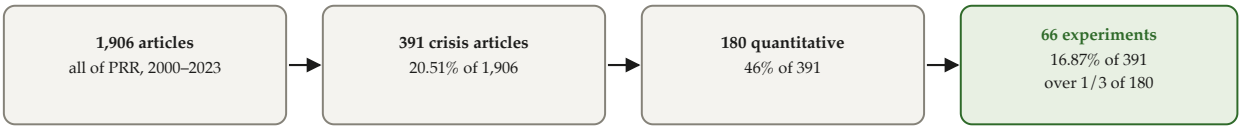


FIGURE 1.1 Each box is a part of the one before it. The final box shows the two ways the paper reports the 66 experiments.

What the authors say, and their reasoning

WHAT THEY SAY	WHY THEY SAY IT
Crisis communication research is largely an "American enterprise"	Authors from 29 countries appear, but United States academics contribute over 70% of the manuscripts, mostly with fellow nationals. They take this as confirming Xifra's (2003) assertion about public relations.
The rise of experiments signals methodological maturation	More than one-third of quantitative studies are experiments, which reflects a shift toward hypothesis-driven, causally oriented research able to isolate how crisis messages work.
There is still room to develop new knowledge	Assuming that synthesis and evaluation objectives contribute most to advancing knowledge, only one in four objectives reaches them, and six in ten objectives are descriptive. Against this, more than three quarters of those descriptive objectives are of medium-high or high complexity.
The search for new crisis theories remains low-profile	Few articles are theoretical only, and the data show a tendency to use recognised theories as lenses for practical cases. The larger set of concepts that could not be classified also suggests broad interest and a more diverse future.

Where the authors say research should go

- **Beyond one journal**: use the framework across a broader range of publications to improve representativeness.
- **Beyond communication alone**: integrate crisis management to give a more holistic understanding of organisational crises.
- **Across cultures and platforms**: investigate strategies in diverse cultural contexts, and the distinct characteristics of social media platforms.

- **Toward prescription**: move from primarily descriptive research to more interpretive and prescriptive studies, including predictive models and artificial intelligence.

Link to next topic → The next chapter opens the method: how the corpus was built and how quickly the field grew.

CHAPTER 2 · PAPER 2 · STUDY AND GROWTH

One journal, 24 years: the study and the growth it found

PROBLEM
Since very little comparable systematic review has been done in the past 25 years, the authors set out to document all the published studies in one journal.

→

BIG IDEA
Code every crisis article in the longest-standing public relations journal.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
A systematic content analysis of 391 articles on 16 categories.

→

RESULT
Crisis communication is the most frequently studied topic in the journal.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Paper 2 is a systematic content analysis of every crisis communication article in *Public Relations Review* (PRR), the oldest public relations journal. Out of 1,906 articles published from 2000 to 2023, 391 dealt with crises once editorials and reviews were removed. Each article was hand-coded on 16 categories in Excel, then re-checked by two analysts.

The first finding is simple growth. Crisis communication is the most frequent topic in the journal at 20.51% of all articles, ahead of social media at 17.94%. Output climbed from a handful of articles a year to 30 a year in 2021 and 2022. In 2020 and 2022, more than a third of everything PRR published was about crises.

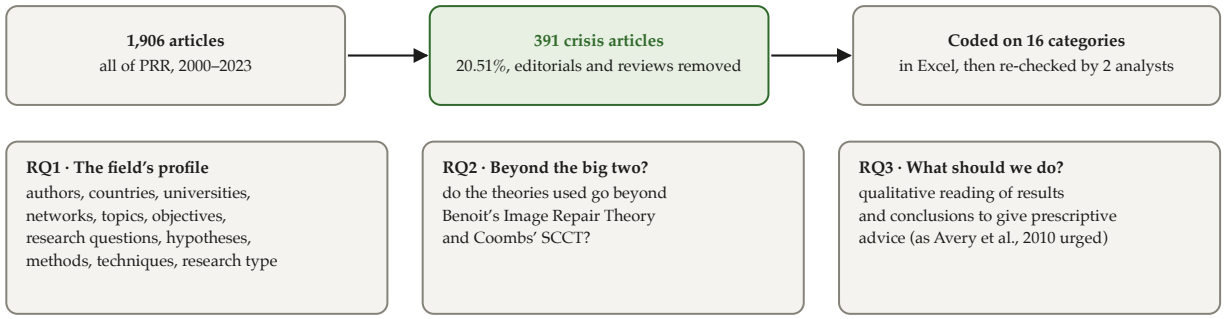


FIGURE 2.1 From the whole journal to the coded corpus, and the three research questions (RQ) the coding serves.

Three research questions

- **RQ1, the profile of the field**: authors, countries, universities, networks, topics, objectives, research questions, hypotheses, methods, techniques and research type.

- **RQ2, beyond the big two**: do the theories used go beyond Benoit's Image Repair Theory and Coombs' Situational Crisis Communication Theory?
- **RQ3, what should be done**: a qualitative reading of results and conclusions to give prescriptive advice, as Avery et al. (2010) urged.

The growth of the field

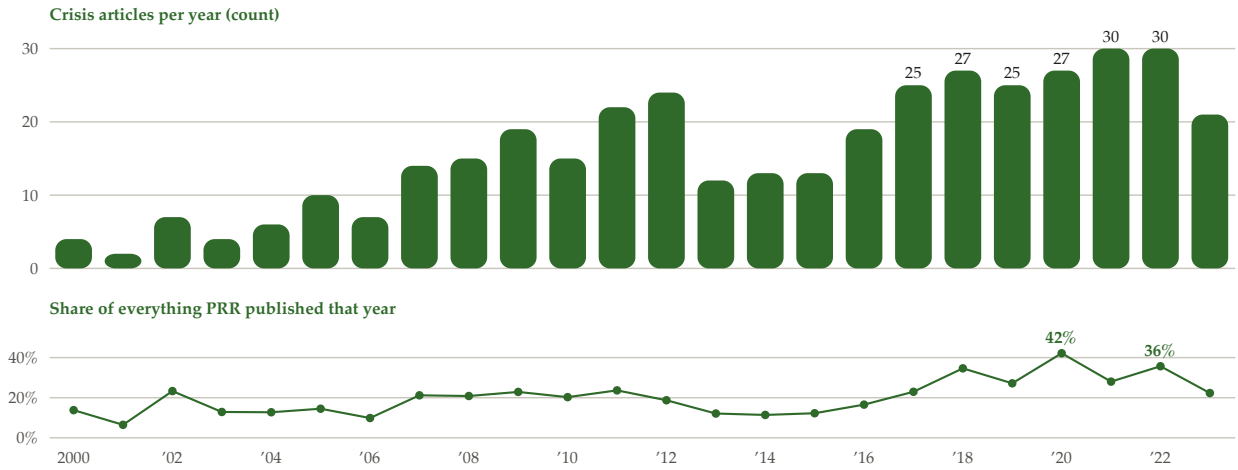


FIGURE 2.2 Output peaked at 30 articles a year in 2021–22. Share peaked in 2020 (42%) and 2022 (36%): in those years more than a third of everything PRR published was about crises. The table below gives every year.

YEAR	CRISIS	ALL	SHARE	YEAR	CRISIS	ALL	SHARE
2000	4	29	14%	2012	24	128	19%
2001	2	31	6%	2013	12	99	12%
2002	7	30	23%	2014	13	114	11%
2003	4	31	13%	2015	13	106	12%
2004	6	47	13%	2016	19	115	17%
2005	10	69	14%	2017	25	109	23%
2006	7	71	10%	2018	27	78	35%
2007	14	66	21%	2019	25	92	27%
2008	15	72	21%	2020	27	64	42%
2009	19	83	23%	2021	30	107	28%
2010	15	74	20%	2022	30	84	36%
2011	22	93	24%	2023	21	94	22%

Link to next topic → With the size of the field established, the next chapter asks who writes this research.

CHAPTER 3 · PAPER 2 · AUTHORS

Who writes it: mostly Americans, mostly in small teams

PROBLEM
The first research question asks about the main authors, countries, universities and networks.

→

BIG IDEA
Count countries, authors and collaboration types across all 391 articles.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
Coding the institution of each author and the type of each collaboration.

→

RESULT
An "American enterprise": 71.35% from the United States, and only 14% crossing borders.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Twenty-nine countries appear in the corpus, but one dominates. Institutions in the United States produced 279 of the 391 articles, or 71.35%. South Korea and Hong Kong follow with 20 each. Asian output is often co-authored with United States partners, in 24 of 33 articles. The University of Maryland leads the institutions with 26 articles, followed by Georgia, Missouri and Tennessee with 16 each.

Most work comes from teams, but those teams stay close to home. Single authors wrote 113 articles, colleagues at the same university 120, and colleagues at different universities in one country 103. Only 55 articles, 14%, are international collaborations. The authors read this as an "American enterprise" with local, inward-looking networks. This is the gap a Korean study such as Paper 1 begins to fill.

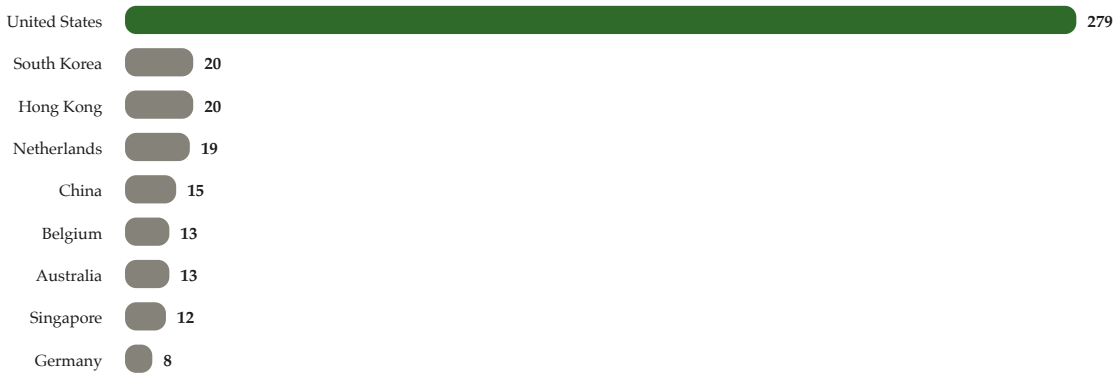


FIGURE 3.1 Country of the author's institution. There are 29 countries in total, and the United States alone produced 71.35%. Asian output is often co-authored with United States partners (24 of 33 articles).

The most prolific authors

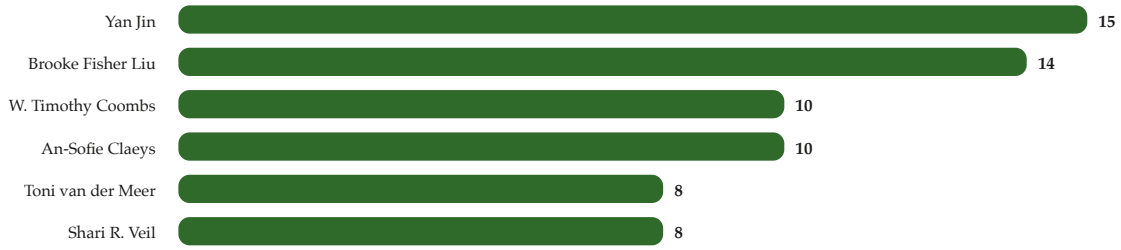


FIGURE 3.2 Most prolific authors, out of 550 distinct authors overall. Top institutions: Maryland (26), then Georgia, Missouri and Tennessee (16 each).

How authors collaborate

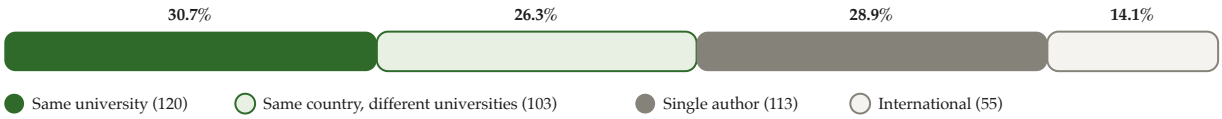


FIGURE 3.3 Collaboration. Most work comes from teams, but only 14% crosses borders. The authors read this as an "American enterprise" with local, inward-looking networks.

Link to next topic → Knowing who writes the research leads to how they carry it out.

CHAPTER 4 · PAPER 2 · METHODS

How the field studies crises: methods and ambition

PROBLEM
The first research question also asks about objectives, research questions, hypotheses, methods and techniques.

→

BIG IDEA
Classify each article by method, technique and the level of its objectives.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
Method counts, technique counts and Bloom's taxonomy of objectives.

→

RESULT
Quantitative work leads and experiments are growing, yet few objectives reach synthesis or evaluation.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Quantitative work leads with 180 articles, 46% of the corpus. Experiments make up 66 of those, which is 16.87% of all articles and over a third of quantitative work, and their share is growing. Qualitative research follows with 110 articles, theory and literature work with 53, and mixed methods with 48. Content analysis is the most common technique at 161 articles, ahead of surveys at 133, and an article can use several.

Bloom's taxonomy sorts learning or research goals into six levels, from knowledge up to evaluation. Applied to 844 stated objectives, it shows a field centred on analysis at 38.15%. Only about one objective in four reaches synthesis or evaluation, the levels that build new knowledge. By type, 59% of objectives are descriptive, 21% correlational and 19% causal.

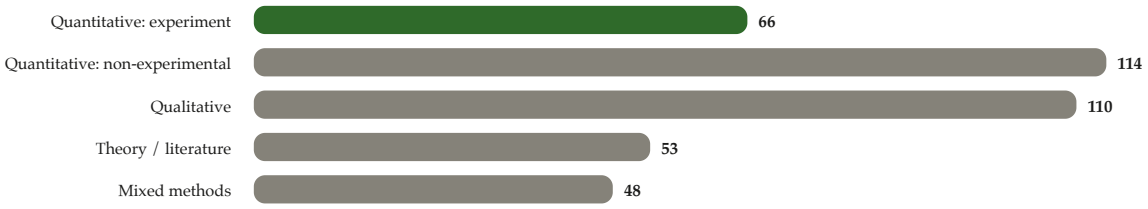


FIGURE 4.1 Method. Quantitative work leads with 180 articles (46%). Experiments are 16.87% of all articles, over a third of quantitative work, and growing (counts converted from the percentages in the paper).

Techniques

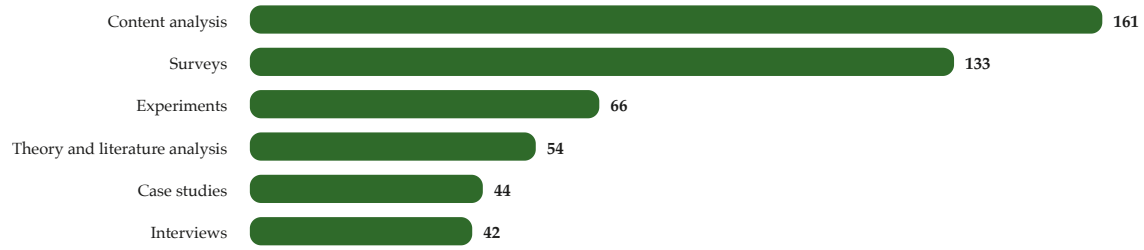


FIGURE 4.2 Techniques. An article can use several, so these counts overlap.

Objectives

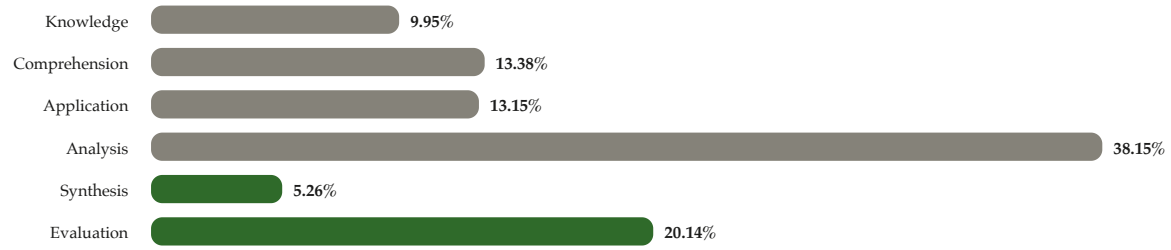


FIGURE 4.3 How ambitious are the objectives? 844 stated objectives sorted by Bloom's taxonomy. Only about 1 in 4 reaches synthesis or evaluation (the two bars in the accent colour), the levels that build new knowledge.

Four more numbers

- **56%** of articles state research questions (652 questions in 220 articles).
- **29%** state hypotheses (486 in 113 articles).
- **35%** are both practical and theoretical; only 12% are purely theoretical.
- **85** articles pair crisis with social media, the top co-topic, followed by reputation (83).

Link to next topic → The second research question turns from methods to the theories behind them.

CHAPTER 5 · PAPER 2 · THEORIES

The theory landscape: the big two and the alternatives

PROBLEM
The second research question asks whether the theories applied go beyond the two dominant ones.

→

BIG IDEA
Separate using a theory from naming it or merely citing its author.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
Three codes for each theory: applied or explained, only named, author cited.

→

RESULT
SCCT is applied in 92 articles, almost twice Image Repair Theory, and alternatives are gaining ground.

IN PLAIN WORDS

The authors separate using a theory, by explaining or testing it, from merely naming it or citing its author. That distinction shows how deep the dominance really is. Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT), from Coombs, is applied in 92 articles, named in 50, and its author is cited without the theory in a further 142. Image Repair Theory (IRT), from Benoit, is applied in 47, named in 55, and its author cited without the theory in 57.

Around these two sit general public relations theories, with 149 uses in total, and a long list of theories borrowed from other fields, with 553 "other" uses. Of those, 180 could not be classified at all. The authors read this larger set of concepts as a sign of broad interest and a more diverse future for the research.

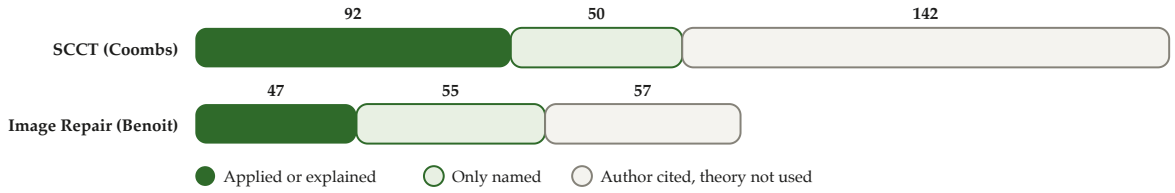


FIGURE 5.1 The big two. SCCT is actually applied in 92 articles, almost twice the 47 for Image Repair Theory. Coombs is also cited 142 more times without his theory (for crisis strategies and image repair work).

General public relations theories

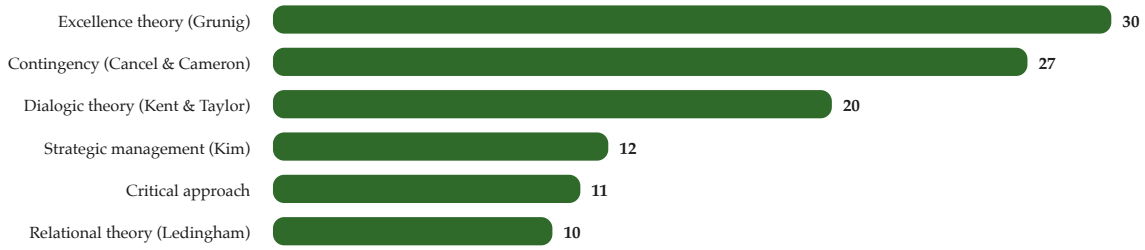


FIGURE 5.2 General public relations theories used in crisis articles (149 uses in total).

Theories from other fields

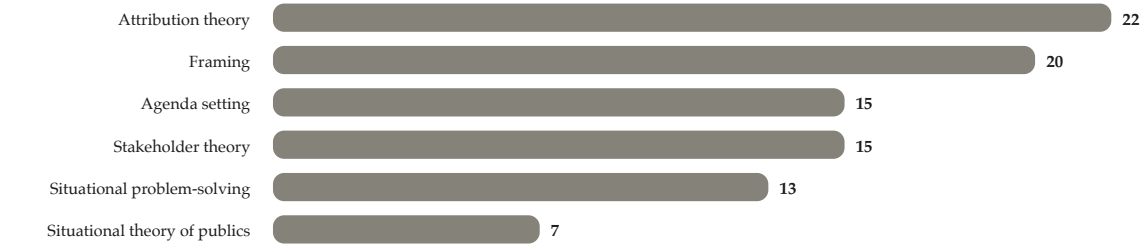


FIGURE 5.3 Selected theories borrowed from elsewhere (553 "other" uses; 180 could not be classified at all). The same list also holds broader labels, led by social media (74), corporate communication (29) and marketing (26).

The alternatives gaining ground

Beyond SCCT and IRT, the paper lists seven alternatives, including the Networked Crisis Communication (NCC) and Social-Mediated Crisis Communication (SMCC) models.

THEORY OR MODEL	THE IDEA	FAMILY
Chaos theory	Crises are non-linear: small triggers, big unpredictable effects.	Complexity
Complexity theory	Organisations are complex systems; control is limited, adaptation matters.	Complexity
Discourse of renewal	Look forward: learning, ethics and rebuilding after the crisis.	Resilience
Situational theory of publics	Publics differ by problem awareness and involvement, so they react differently.	Resilience
Contingency theory of accommodation	Stance slides from advocacy to accommodation depending on 86 contingency factors.	Stance

NCC model	The medium changes the effect: same message, different reaction on social and traditional media.	Digital
SMCC model	Maps who spreads crisis information online: influencers, followers, inactive users.	Digital

Link to next topic → The third research question asks what all this research adds up to in practice.

CHAPTER 6 · PAPER 2 · FINDINGS

What 24 years of findings add up to: four pillars

PROBLEM
Avery et al. (2010) urged the field to become more prescriptive, and the third research question follows that suggestion.

→

BIG IDEA
Read the results and conclusions together, then draw prescriptive advice from them.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
A qualitative reading of the results and conclusions of the articles.

→

RESULT
Four pillars: preparedness, transparency, narrative and digital agility.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Four themes recur across the results. More than 60% of articles report that crisis plans reduce harm, about 50% that transparency restores trust, more than 45% that social media amplifies the crisis, and about 40% that human narratives rebuild image. These shares are approximate, because the paper gives them without a coding table.

The conclusions turn these themes into four pillars. Prepare with plans, trained teams, set spokespersons and simulations. Disclose quickly and accurately, keeping words in line with actions, because evasion costs more later. Humanise the organisation through testimonies, empathy and a proactive tone. Monitor online talk and answer rumours quickly, with prediction and artificial intelligence (AI) as the future direction.

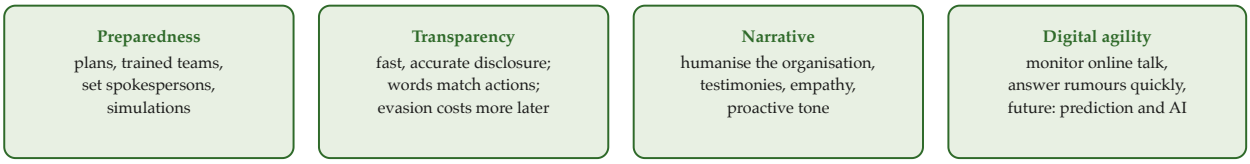


FIGURE 6.1 The four pillars the authors draw from the conclusions of the reviewed articles.

The result themes



FIGURE 6.2 Result themes and the approximate share of articles reporting each.

Specific practical findings

Beneath the pillars sit specific findings from the reviewed studies, each with a practical consequence.

FINDING	SO WHAT
In online firestorms, **silence** reduced negative feeling more than other responses; **sympathetic** replies drew more engagement	Choose the response by goal: calm the storm or engage the public
Organisations stayed silent when negative mentions were few and explained more when they were many	Volume of online criticism shapes strategy; adapt, do not script
The faster people get information, the more effective they judge the response	Speed is part of the message
United Airlines case: Chinese-language posts focused on the passenger's ethnicity, English posts on the company's response	Different cultural audiences assign blame differently
"Multivocality": many voices now speak in the crisis arena, not just the organisation	The organisation no longer controls the story alone

Link to next topic → Before relying on these numbers, the next chapter checks how far they can be trusted.

CHAPTER 7 · PAPER 2 · ANALYSIS

Strengths, limits and numbers to read carefully

PROBLEM
The authors acknowledge limits: the focus on one journal and the absence of an inter-rater reliability assessment.

→

BIG IDEA
A census of one journal maps that journal, and printed figures need reading carefully.

→

HOW (TOOLS)
The limits the authors state, and the checks recorded in the study notes.

→

RESULT
Use it for background, theory choice and research gaps.

IN PLAIN WORDS

As the study notes read it, the strength of Paper 2 is that it is a census of 24 years rather than a sample. Its coding is also rich: objectives by two taxonomies, hypotheses by two, and theory use separated from theory mention. The notes add that it answers a real question for students, namely which theory to pick and what is under-studied, and that it is recent and open access under a Creative Commons licence (CC BY).

The limits are these. One journal shows the taste of *Public Relations Review* (PRR) and not the whole field. No inter-rater reliability statistic is reported, such as Cohen's Kappa, which would show that independent coders agree; disagreements were settled by discussion. And by focusing on organisational crises, the paper excludes disaster and public-health crisis research by design. The authors also leave out crisis management, as a broader managerial field, on purpose.

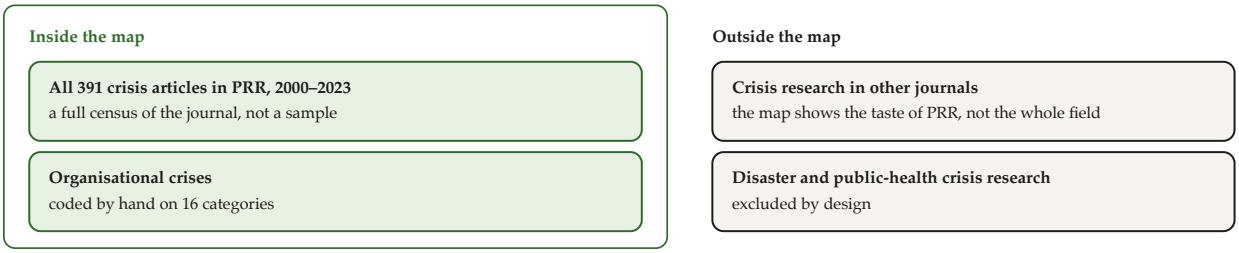


FIGURE 7.1 The authors note that the focus on one journal restricts how far the results generalise to the broader field of crisis communication.

Read the numbers carefully

- **Corpus size**: 391 in the abstract and methods, but 386 in the introduction.
- **Team-authored articles**: 278 of 391 is 71.1%, but the text says 70.09%. Similarly, Fig. 3 prints 35.4% where the text says 35.04%.

- **“SCCT n = 142”**: this appears as the count for Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) in one place, and as the count of Coombs citations without the theory in another. The safer figure for “SCCT used” is 92.
- **Result themes**: percentages such as “more than 60%” and “about 50%” come without a coding table, so they are approximate.
- **Annex 1**: the full list of crisis theories, models and stages is in an annex that is not in the PDF.

> **Do not quote 142 as SCCT use:** 142 counts articles citing Coombs without using the theory. The paper separates using the theory (92), merely naming it (50) and citing the author only (142).

Test yourself

– Paper 2 says SCCT is used in 92 articles. Why not quote 142?

142 is the number of articles citing Coombs *without* using SCCT. The authors distinguish using a theory (92), merely naming it (50), and citing the author only (142).

Link to next topic → The Overview tab sets the two papers side by side and draws out what they teach together.